like many other places where the emperor's epigraphs had been inscribed, part of a sacred vicinity or near an ancient shrine? Perhaps. The attractions of engraving royal messages into rock here may have been considerable, given the availability of carvable rock. Many centuries later the Cehel Zina of the first Mughal Babur, commemorating his battle against the city in the early sixteenth century, was cut into the same mountains that protect old Kandahar.[19] Ashoka's engraving was conceivably visible and known to later wayfarers on this trail, though it is likely that Babur's engravers, encountering it, would not have made head or tail of what their predecessors were getting at.

In the third century BCE, what would have drawn residents and visitors to this chipping and grinding will have been the fact that the emperor's message was in two familiar languages. The other messages that we waded through, which were sent out around the same time as this one, were a fairly similar broadcast, being also in the same language and script. This first Afghan rescript of Ashoka, on the other hand, used neither the Brahmi script nor the Prakrit vocabulary of the carvings we saw earlier. Greek and Aramaic were served instead, the Greek featuring above the Aramaic, keeping two readerships in mind. An example of such bilingualism is the medieval stone tablet discovered in the foundations of a monastery near the Gauri-Kedara temple at Bhubaneswar in Orissa. The tablet was inscribed in Oriya and Tamil because it recorded a transaction between a debtor, a man of Tamil descent associated with the monastery, and a creditor, a moneyed Oriya.[20] Many centuries before this, in large parts of Asia and beyond, epigraphic records in more than one language had become a fairly familiar sight. With the Achaemenids, in fact, multilingual inscriptions became almost the rule, the earliest and best-known example being the monumental epigraph on a limestone cliff on Mount Behistun in the Kermanshah province of western Iran. Here, Darius I (Darius 'the Great') of the sixth century BCE had a trilingual epigraph inscribed in old Persian, Elamite, and